

Skin Manifestations and Classification of Lupus Erythematosus

Discoid lupus erythematosus (DLE) causes scarring and can lead to permanent disfigurement. In contrast, **subacute cutaneous lupus erythematosus (SCLE)** and **acute cutaneous lupus erythematosus (ACLE)** are highly photosensitive and typically non-scarring.

Lupus Erythematosus–Non-Specific Skin Lesions

These include: - Non-scarring alopecia - Mouth ulcers - Photosensitivity - Raynaud phenomenon - Vasculitis/vasculopathy

These lesions are not specific to lupus but often precede or herald a flare of **systemic lupus erythematosus (SLE)**.

Pathogenesis of SLE

SLE is a disorder in which the interplay between host factors (such as genetic susceptibility and hormonal influences) and environmental triggers (including ultraviolet radiation, viral infections, and certain drugs) results in a loss of self-tolerance and the development of autoimmunity. This leads to immune system activation and expansion, ultimately causing immunologic tissue injury.

Treatment

Management of lupus erythematosus includes: - Sunscreens - Topical and short-term systemic glucocorticoids - Antimalarial agents - Retinoids - Immunosuppressive drugs - Thalidomide - Biologic therapies

Epidemiology

Lupus erythematosus occurs significantly more often in women, with a female-to-male ratio of approximately 9:1.

TABLE 156-1: The Gilliam Classification of Skin Lesions Associated with Lupus Erythematosus

I. LE-specific skin disease [Cutaneous LE (CLE)]	II. LE–non-specific skin disease
A. Acute cutaneous LE (ACLE)	A. Cutaneous vascular disease
1. Localized ACLE (malar rash; butterfly rash)	1. Vasculitis
2. Generalized ACLE (lupus maculopapular rash, photosensitive lupus dermatitis)	a. Leukocytoclastic
	(1) Palpable purpura
	(2) Urticarial vasculitis
	b. Periarthritis nodosa–like lesions
B. Subacute cutaneous LE (SCLE)	2. Vasculopathy
1. Annular SCLE (lupus marginatus, symmetric erythema centrifugum, etc.)	a. Degos disease–like lesions
2. Papulosquamous SCLE (psoriasiform, pityriasiform, maculopapular photosensitive LE, etc.)	b. Secondary atrophie blanche (livedoid vasculitis)
	3. Periungual telangiectasia
	4. Livedo reticularis
	5. Thrombophlebitis
	6. Raynaud phenomenon
	7. Erythromelalgia (erythermalgia)
C. Chronic cutaneous LE (CCLE)	B. Non-scarring alopecia
1. Classic discoid LE (DLE)	1. “Lupus hair”
a. Localized DLE	2. Telogen effluvium
b. Generalized DLE	3. Alopecia areata
2. Hypertrophic/verrucous DLE	C. Sclerodactyly
3. Lupus profundus/lupus panniculitis	D. Mucosal ulcers